‘Anyway . . . how do you plan to lose weight if we recommend you?’ he asked. It was a valid question. I was overweight according to Indian Air Force standards. Any other civilian would consider me fit, but this was the Indian Air Force, and they were looking for leaner and meaner air warriors.

‘My father will help me lose weight with regular physical training,’ I replied, and since they knew I was the daughter of an army officer, they knew my father would see to it that I did sweat and burn it off. You cannot outmatch a ‘fauji’ when it comes to physical training.

‘All right, that will be all,’ the IO said. ‘Please wait outside for the results. We wish you luck.’

An hour passed and impatience got the better of me. To divert my mind, I paced the corridor, while everyone around me discussed and reassessed their performance. Even when I tried to think, I could not recall the sequence of events that had happened inside. I almost forgot my answers to the IO’s questions. Did I use too many gestures? Did I even move my hands? Was I sitting straight? Did I blink too much? Was my leg shaking? I could not remember anything. One after another, the candidates kept going in and coming out. By lunchtime, all the interviews were over. The red bulb lit up again. Another countdown! I started to think about my dogs. Their memories made me smile and I felt better. But the feeling lasted only until Sqn Ldr Yadav came out with a page in his hand. I could feel my heart pounding in my chest. All of us sat in our chairs quietly and waited for him to speak.

‘After compiling the results of the tests,’ he announced, ‘I’d like to tell you that all of you cleared the PABT exam.’ The girls looked at each other. The suspense still lingered. ‘But to everyone’s hard luck, there’s only one candidate the board has recommended today.’ No sooner had he said this than my face dropped. *It’s definitely not going to be me*. But I wanted it to be.

‘Chest Number 4,’ Sqn Ldr Yadav announced, his eyes scanning the crowd and stopping at me. I partially raised my right hand.
‘Congratulations, you’ve made it!’ Sqn Ldr Yadav said. ‘Please meet me in my office. The others may leave. I wish you all the very best of luck.’